

DARKNESS AND immorality

THE ROMANTIC ERA

The Romantic movement in art, music, and literature emerged in the late 18th and early 19th centuries as a reaction to the ideals of the Enlightenment. Whereas the earlier movement had been about knowledge, progress, and reason, Romanticism took an opposite approach, exploring themes of darkness, passion, the natural world, and immorality. Women were more present in literature than any other Romantic art form, using their writing to express their sexuality and to criticize the social order. Christina Rossetti's "Goblin Market," for example, uses forbidden fruit as an allegory for women's sexual temptation, sacrifice, and salvation. It also features and criticizes male sexual violence: when one sister is seduced by the "goblins" in the poem, they abuse her by holding her down and tearing her dress.

A dark genre

The Gothic, which developed as a popular subgenre of Romantic literature, also appealed to female writers. It was characterized by its gloomy settings—abandoned castles or eerie forests—and what was called the "explained supernatural," in which fantastical ideas had pseudoscientific explanations. An early pioneer was Ann Radcliffe, a British writer whose *Mysteries of Udolpho* (1794), a Gothic romance with a female protagonist, became a literary sensation. Gothic literature allowed women to explore psychological issues—as in the case of American writer Charlotte Perkins Gilman, who wrote *The Yellow Wallpaper* (1892) about a woman's descent into madness. Gothic literature also dealt with religion: Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) criticized



◀ Fairy tales and folk stories

This book of Grimm tales was published in Berlin in 1865. Their versions, and variations by other male writers, still form the foundations of many tales.

the arrogance of man trying to play God, pioneering the fantasy horror genre.

Folk traditions

Romanticism was spurred by nationalist ideas, as people used art to reinforce their national identity. During Napoleon's empire (see pp. 146–147),

resistance movements sprang up in conquered nations to celebrate their own dialects and traditions. Folk music and tales were recorded by artists collecting songs and stories; Jacob and Wilhelm, the "Brothers Grimm," were part of this movement, and collected hundreds of tales to edit for a 19th-century audience. Many of these tales came from Dortchen Wild, an aristocratic girl who lived in the castle of Hesse-Cassel—taken over by the French in 1806. She eventually married Wilhelm Grimm, but received no credit for her stories. In their new forms, the Grimm tales pushed the very moral agendas that female Romantics criticized. *Rotkäppchen* (Little Red Cap), for example, was a symbolic warning for girls not to be promiscuous, lest they be eaten (ruined) by the wolf (man).

Tales recorded by men starkly contrasted those written by women. In the 18th century, French salon host Madame d'Aulnoy and her peers wrote stories criticizing monarchy, marriage, and religion, featuring quick-witted heroines. Yet such stories faded into obscurity, while the Grimms and Charles Perrault (author of the Mother Goose tales) were hailed as the fathers of the modern fairy tale.

◀ Sexual allegory

In Christina Rossetti's "Goblin Market" (1862), Laura has no money, so she trades locks of her hair to buy fruit from goblin men. Using fruit to refer to Adam and Eve, Rossetti's poem symbolizes the forbidden nature of female sexuality.